



WIKILEAKS ACCEPTS BITCOIN

012 / 14 JUN 2011 / BITCOIN / UNCOMMON

BITCOIN DONATIONS.

In the artwork, a woman brings one small coin to an open donation hatch. Three larger payment doors are chained shut behind her. There was no such stone arcade: its scale makes a financial blockade visible, while the coin draws the eye to the route that remained available.

By late 2010, several conventional payment services had stopped processing donations to WikiLeaks. On 14 June 2011, WikiLeaks publicly announced that it was accepting Bitcoin donations and posted a receiving address. Its announcement called them “anonymous Bitcoin donations.” That was the organization's description at the time, not a promise the card makes to anyone donating.

A person with Bitcoin could send it to a published address without those particular card and payment processors completing the transfer. This offered another route for contributions, but it did not remove every practical obstacle to obtaining or using Bitcoin. Transactions also leave a public record. Researchers studying the network in 2011 warned that donations to a public address could be linked to other activity or to people.

The moment matters because a small, experimental payment network became a practical alternative in a public dispute over access to financial services. The picture holds the two ideas together: the closed doors are formidable, and the donation is modest. The opening is real as a choice; the illustrated hatch is a metaphor.

HIDDEN IN THE ART

01 THE CLOSED DOORS

Chained “CARD PAYMENTS,” “BANK” and “ONLINE PAYMENTS” shutters stand for restricted conventional donation channels. The red lights and building are invented visual shorthand.

02 FAMILIAR COLOURS

Muted overlapping red and orange circles and two shades of blue hint at the kinds of payment services involved. They are art cues, not official logos or a claim of endorsement.

03 THE OLD BANK

A faint three-column bank façade is carved behind “BANK,” representing traditional financial institutions rather than one particular bank.

04 THE RECEIPT

“DONATION / 14 JUN 2011” distinguishes a contribution from a purchase. The paper receipt and the anonymous donor are imagined; the date marks the public announcement.

05 THE HALF-HIDDEN LETTER

Only the left side of the cream Blind Signatures letter from card 001 peeks out behind the envelopes in the open hatch. It links the series' earlier electronic-cash ideas to this later use, not an actual 2011 delivery.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

The [contemporary Forbes report](#) records the 14 June announcement and the payment restrictions. WikiLeaks' [banking-blockade account](#) gives its later account of affected services. Reid and Harrigan's 2011 [research paper](#) reproduces the original announcement and examines the limits of anonymity around a public donation address. “BITCOIN DONATIONS.” is a short continuous excerpt of the preserved announcement, with presentation case and punctuation normalized. The donor, arcade, hatch, chains, receipt and borrowed 001 letter are illustrated metaphors. The category-sign colours and circles need separate commercial-rights review before printing.